

Antioxidant Rich Foods

A Practical Reference for Daily Nutrition

Antioxidants are compounds that help protect the body's cells from damage caused by free radicals. Free radicals are unstable molecules produced during normal metabolism and exposure to pollution, smoke, and ultraviolet light. A diet rich in antioxidant-containing foods supports general health and well-being.

What Are Antioxidants?

Antioxidants include vitamins such as vitamin C and vitamin E, minerals such as selenium, and a large group of plant compounds called phytochemicals. Common phytochemicals with antioxidant activity include flavonoids, polyphenols, carotenoids, and anthocyanins. These compounds are found naturally in fruits, vegetables, whole grains, nuts, seeds, and beverages such as green tea.

Top Food Sources

Several food groups are particularly rich in antioxidants. Berries such as blueberries, strawberries, and raspberries are well known for their high anthocyanin content. Dark leafy greens including spinach and kale provide lutein and zeaxanthin. Nuts and seeds supply vitamin E. Dark chocolate and cocoa contain flavanols. Green tea and black tea contribute catechins.

Suggested Items:

- Fresh berries with breakfast cereal or curd
- A handful of mixed nuts as a mid-morning snack
- Spinach or kale in salads, soups, and dals
- Brewed green tea after meals
- Two squares of dark chocolate (70 percent cocoa or higher)

Reference Table

Food	Key Antioxidant	Typical Serving
Blueberries	Anthocyanins	1 cup
Spinach	Lutein, Vitamin C	1 cup raw
Almonds	Vitamin E	1 ounce (about 23 nuts)
Dark Chocolate	Flavanols	1 to 2 squares
Green Tea	Catechins	1 cup brewed

Conclusion

A varied diet that includes a colorful mix of fruits, vegetables, nuts, seeds, and whole grains generally provides a useful range of antioxidants. Supplementation is rarely necessary when the diet is balanced.